Website Heuristic Analysis

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Advanced Topics in Hypermedia / Multimedia Design

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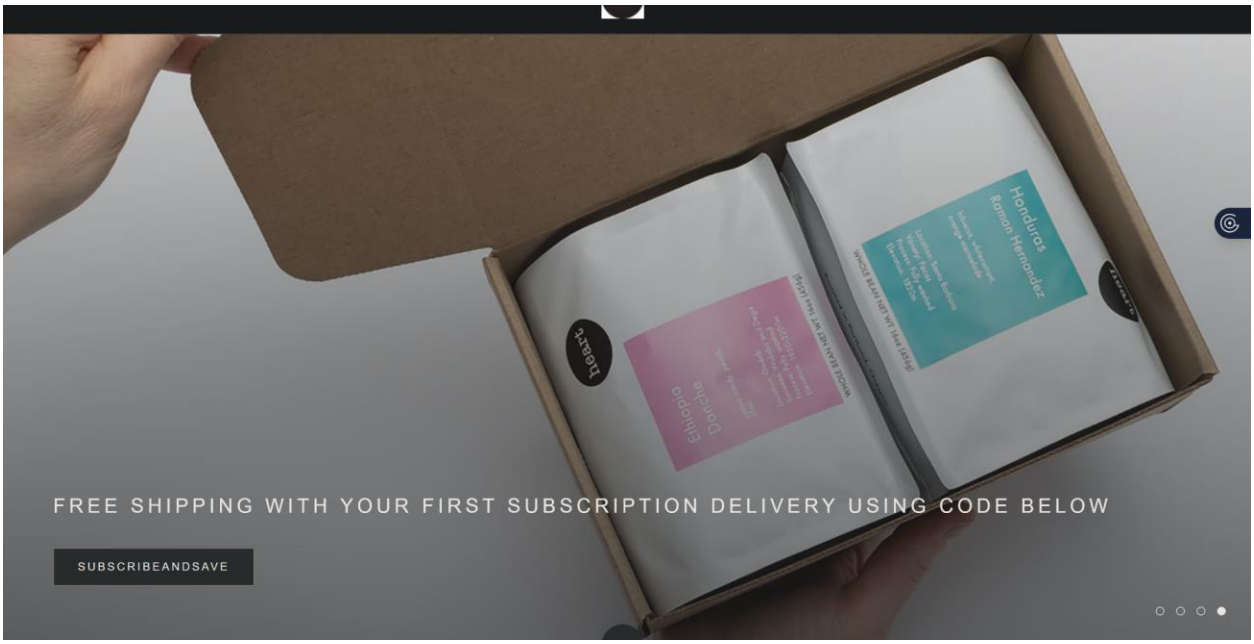
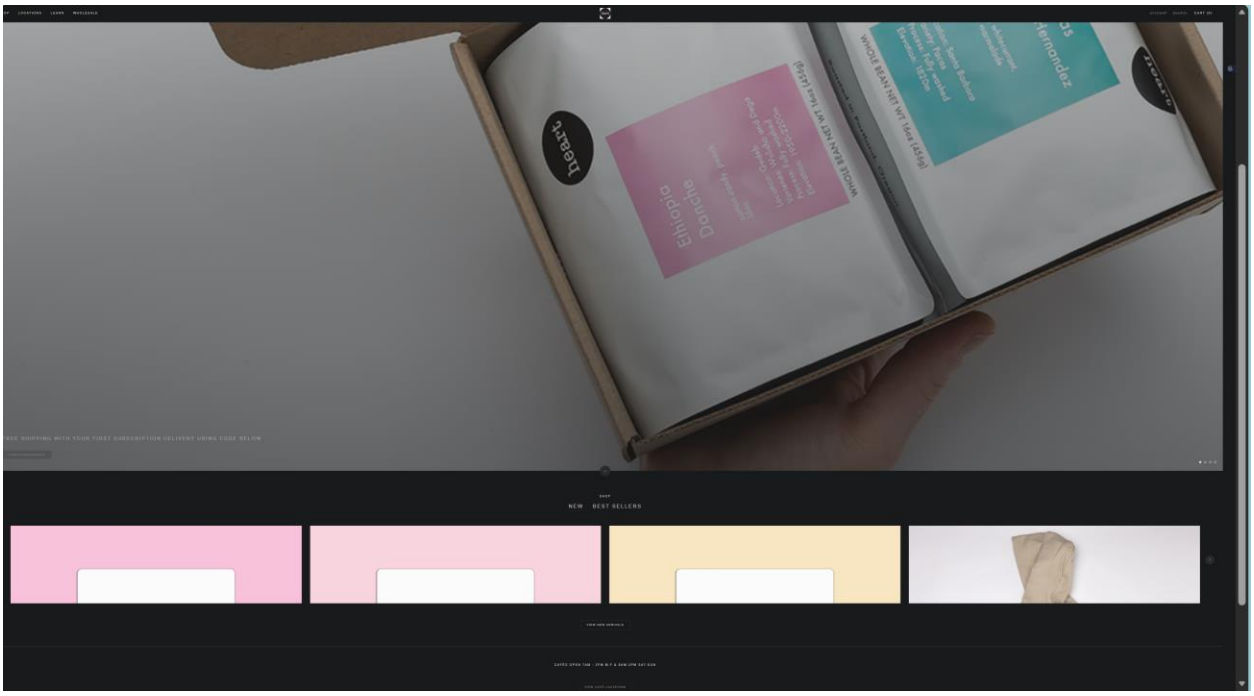
3 Coffee Shops, 3 Cities — Website Heuristic Analytics

Heart Roasters Homepage

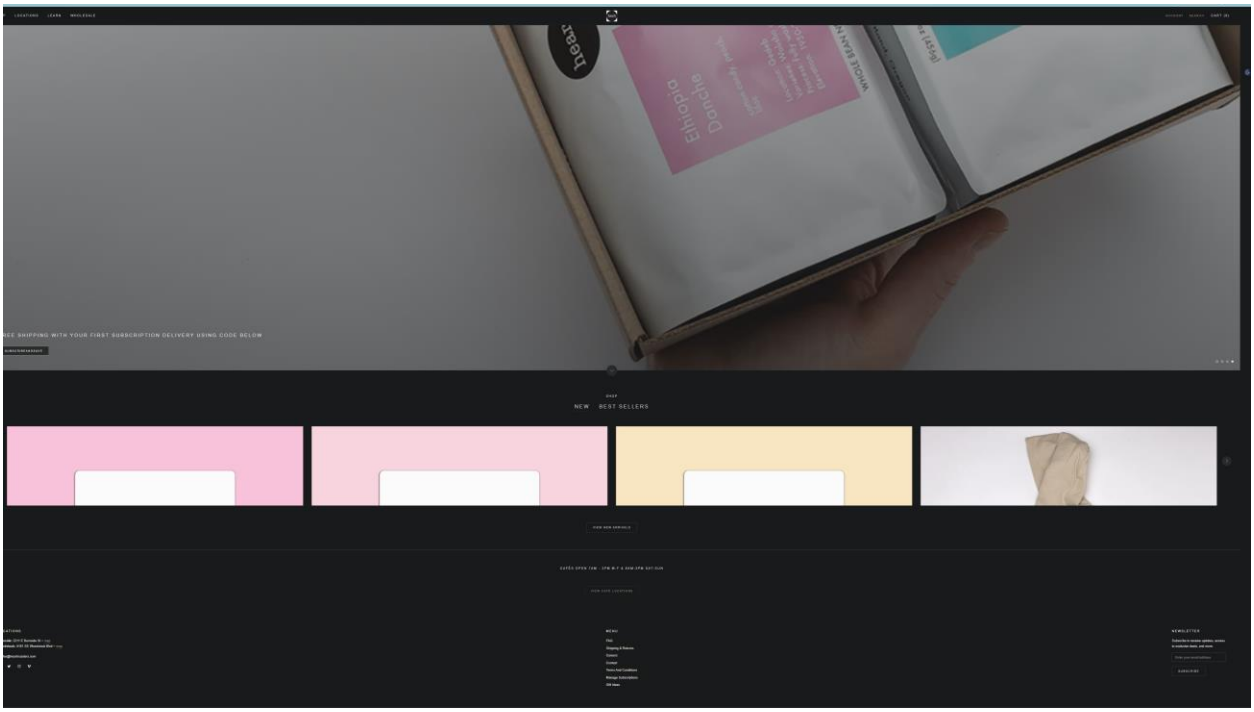
The homepage of Heart Roasters demonstrates a strong emphasis on **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design (Heuristic #8)**. The layout is clean, visually appealing, and uncluttered, featuring a rotating set of large images that highlight featured coffees, merchandise, and subscription offerings. Because only one primary message is shown at a time, the design avoids overwhelming users with excessive information. Optional sections such as best sellers and location hours appear lower on the page, allowing users to explore additional content without forcing it upon them.



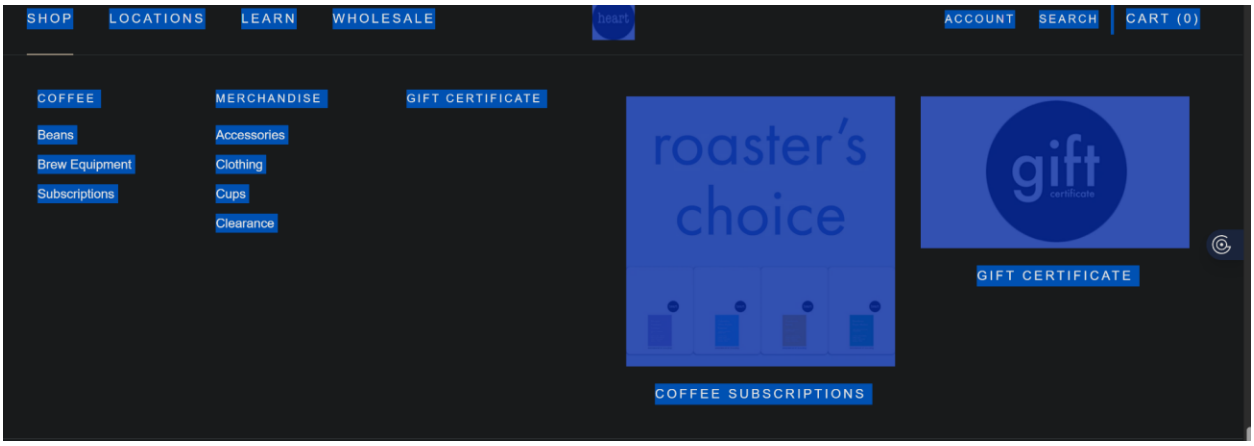
The site also supports **Recognition Rather Than Recall (Heuristic #6)**. Product images, packaging, and promotional visuals make it easy for users to identify offerings without needing to remember names or details. For example, the image of the subscription box containing two coffee bags communicates the concept of a delivery service immediately. This visual approach reduces cognitive effort and supports quick decision-making.



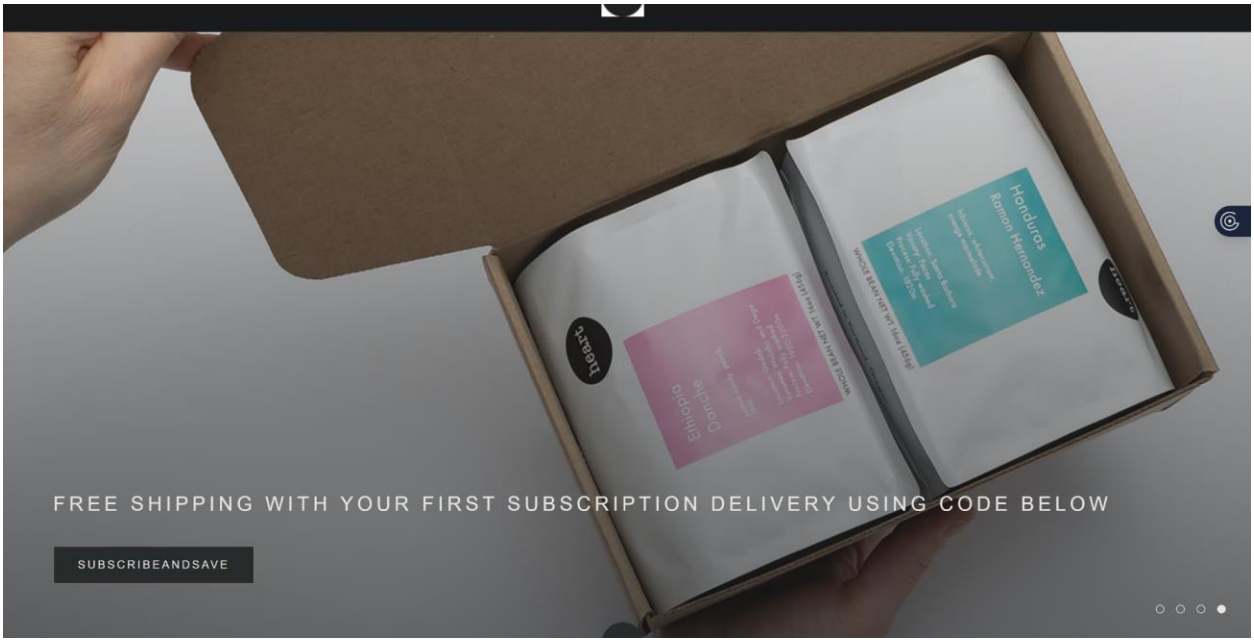
However, the rotating carousel weakens **Visibility of System Status (Heuristic #1)**. Users may not realize that the images are part of a slideshow or understand how many slides exist. While navigation dots are present, they are small and visually subtle, which may reduce discoverability. Without clear feedback or controls, users may miss important content if the slide changes automatically.



The navigation menu demonstrates **Consistency and Standards (Heuristic #4)** by using familiar e-commerce categories such as Shop, Locations, Learn, and Wholesale. These labels align with user expectations and industry conventions, making the site easier to understand. The subcategories within the shop menu are logically organized, supporting efficient navigation.



At the same time, some usability issues arise from typography choices. Call-to-action text such as “SUBSCRIBEANDSAVE” lacks spacing between words, which reduces readability and slows scanning. This issue affects both **Match Between the System and the Real World (Heuristic #2)** and **Recognition Rather Than Recall (Heuristic #6)** because users must spend extra effort interpreting the text rather than understanding it instantly.



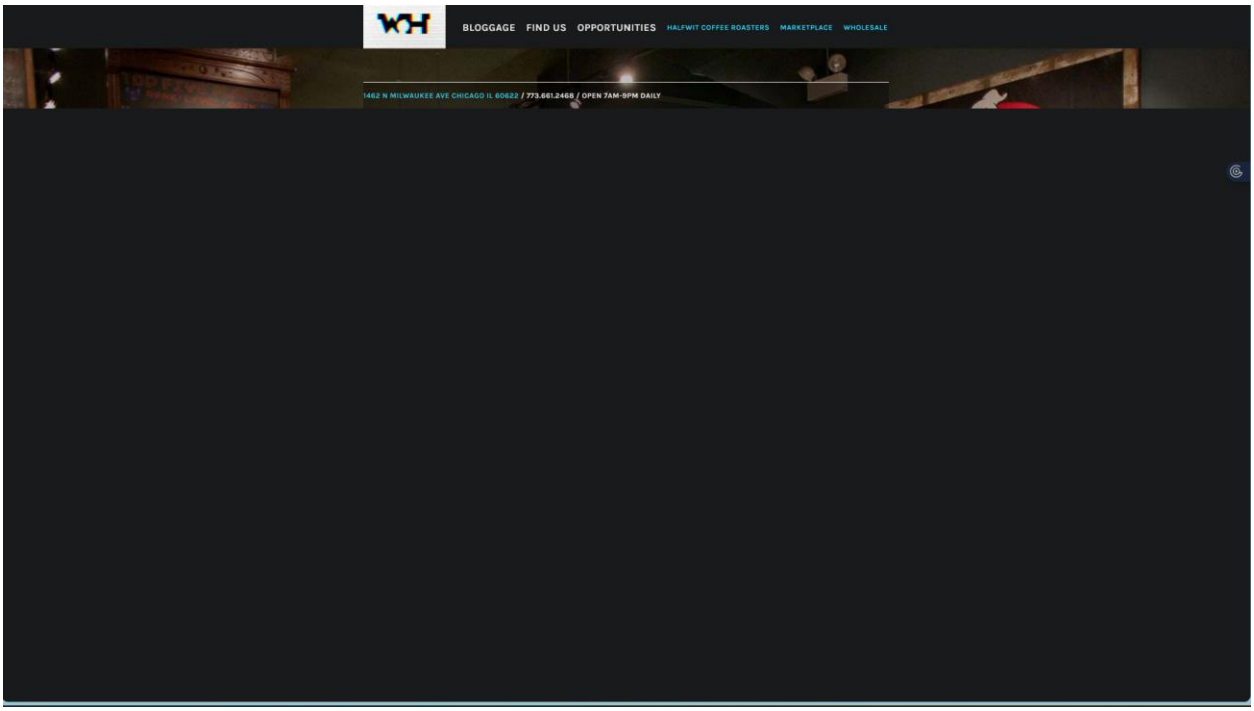
Overall, the design achieves an effective balance between aesthetics and usability. The minimalist layout enhances visual appeal and prevents cognitive overload, while recognizable

imagery and standard navigation support task completion. Minor adjustments to feedback, typography, and carousel controls would further improve usability without compromising the site's clean visual identity.

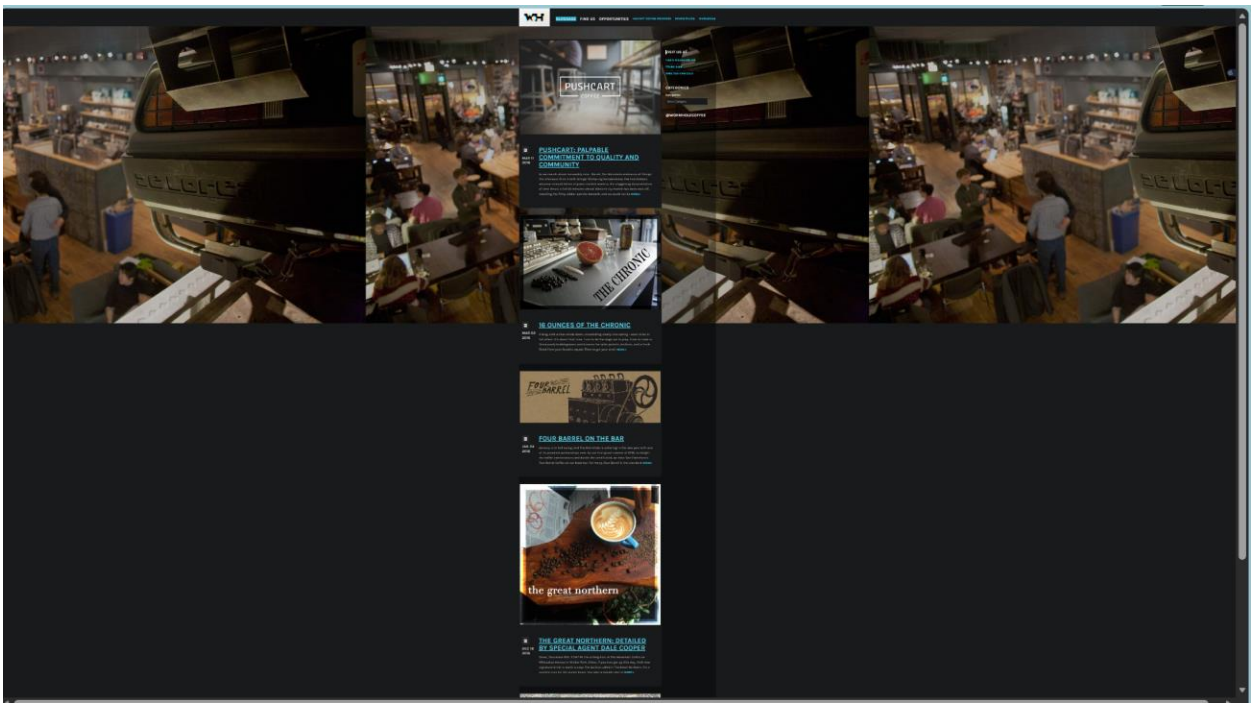
Website Critique Using Usability Heuristics

Site: The Wormhole Coffee

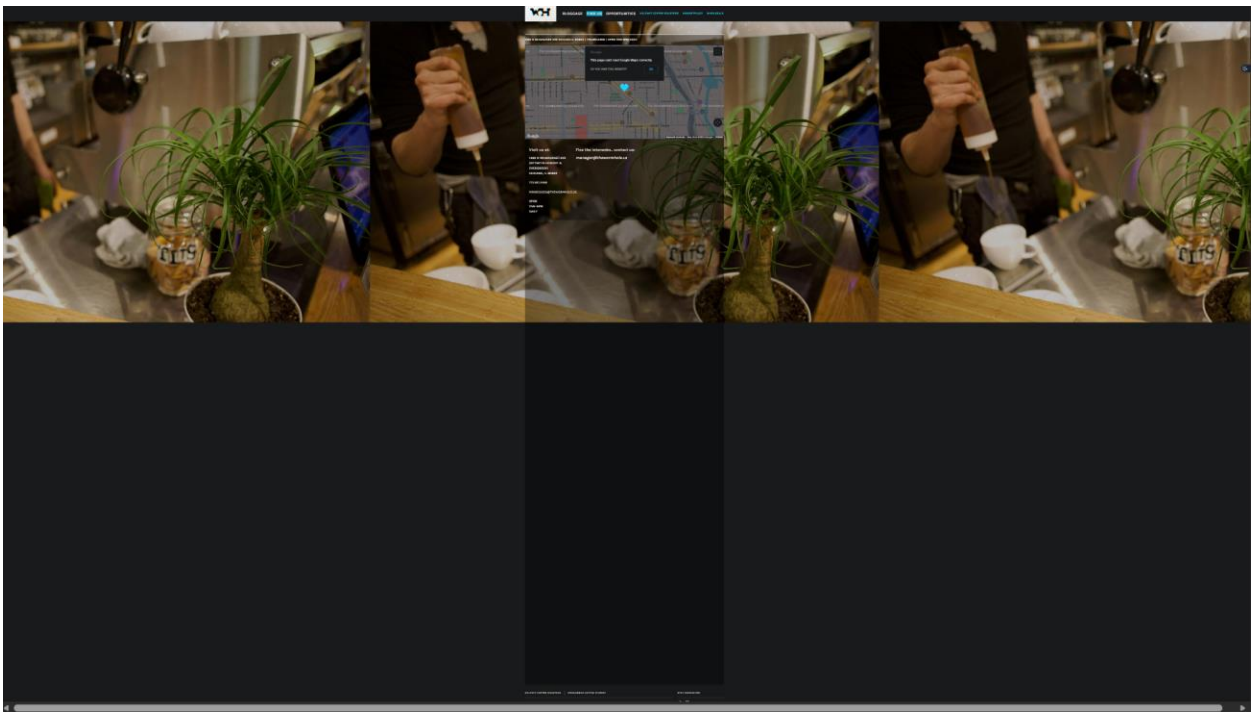
The homepage currently lacks visible content, which creates immediate confusion about whether the site is functioning properly. This violates **Visibility of System Status (Heuristic 1)** because users receive no clear feedback about what the site is or what they can do there. A homepage is typically expected to present core information, branding, or navigation cues. Instead, the empty appearance may lead users to believe the page failed to load or is incomplete.



The blog ("Bloggage") section contains articles presented over large background images of the café interior, which successfully communicates atmosphere and personality. This supports **Match Between System and the Real World (Heuristic 2)** because the visuals reflect the physical environment customers would experience. However, when zooming out, a large gray area becomes visible beneath the content, suggesting the layout does not scale properly. This weakens **Flexibility and Efficiency of Use (Heuristic 7)**, as the design does not adapt smoothly to different viewing conditions.

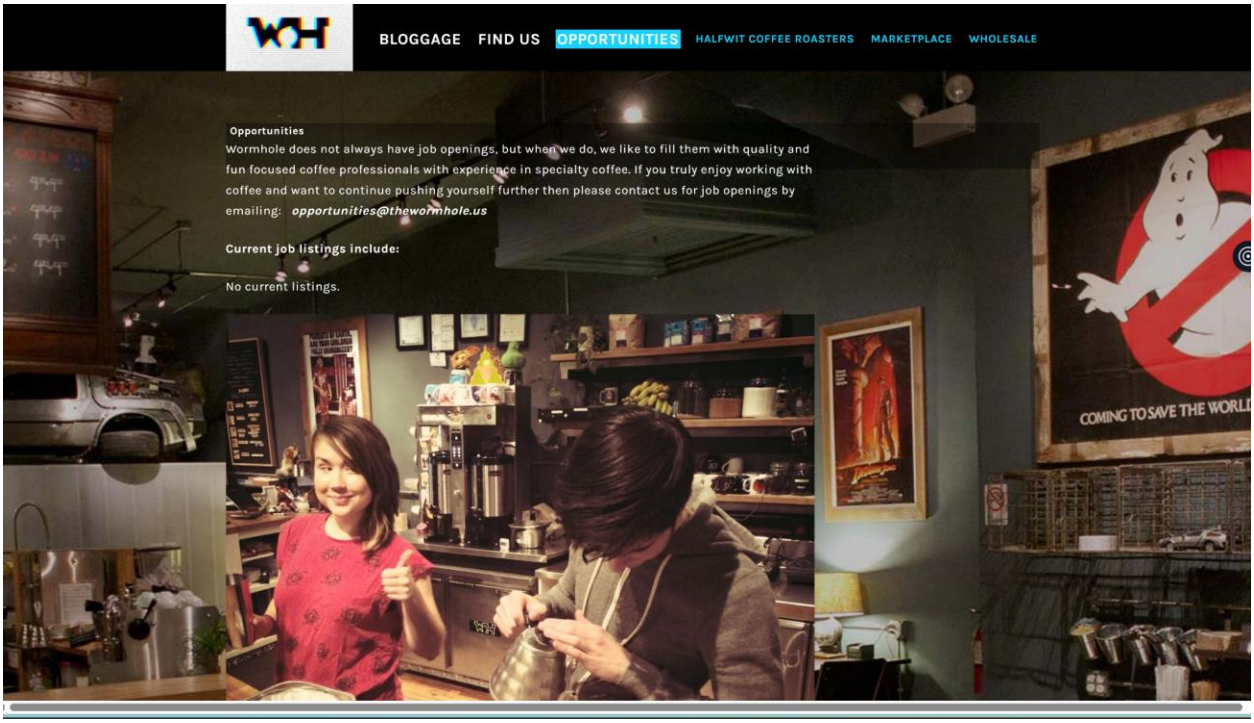


The “Find Us” page displays location information over a similar background image but shows the same issue when zoomed out, exposing empty space at the bottom of the screen. While the content itself is useful, the incomplete layout reduces visual cohesion and may make the site appear unfinished. Consistent presentation across different screen sizes is an important aspect of usability and contributes to user confidence in the site’s reliability.



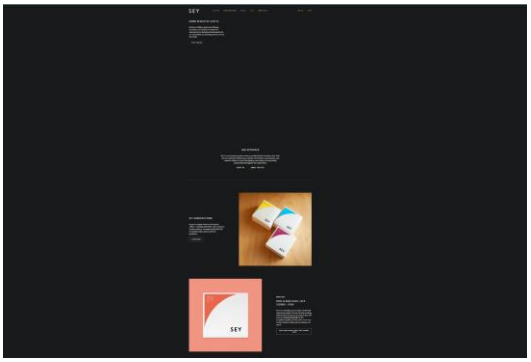
The job opportunities section communicates the café's character and the type of environment they want to create, emphasizing passion and community. This aligns with **Match Between System and the Real World (Heuristic 2)** by using language and imagery that reflect the business's identity. However, when users attempt to learn about the café's coffee, they are redirected to Halfwit Coffee Roasters. This transition may feel unexpected and disrupt continuity, conflicting with **Consistency and Standards (Heuristic 4)**. Users typically expect information about products to remain within the same site unless clearly explained.

Overall, the site conveys a strong sense of personality but struggles with structural clarity and continuity. Missing homepage content, layout issues when scaling, and unexpected redirection create friction that interferes with usability. Improving feedback, maintaining consistent page behavior across zoom levels, and clearly explaining external links would help balance the site's distinctive aesthetic with functional clarity.



SEY Coffee Website

The SEY Coffee website demonstrates a strong emphasis on **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design (Heuristic #8)**. The interface is clean, modern, and visually cohesive, using ample negative space and consistent color palettes to create a refined presentation. Product packaging is displayed prominently, and each item follows a uniform layout that prevents visual clutter despite the large number of offerings. This minimalist approach allows users to focus on the products themselves without distraction.

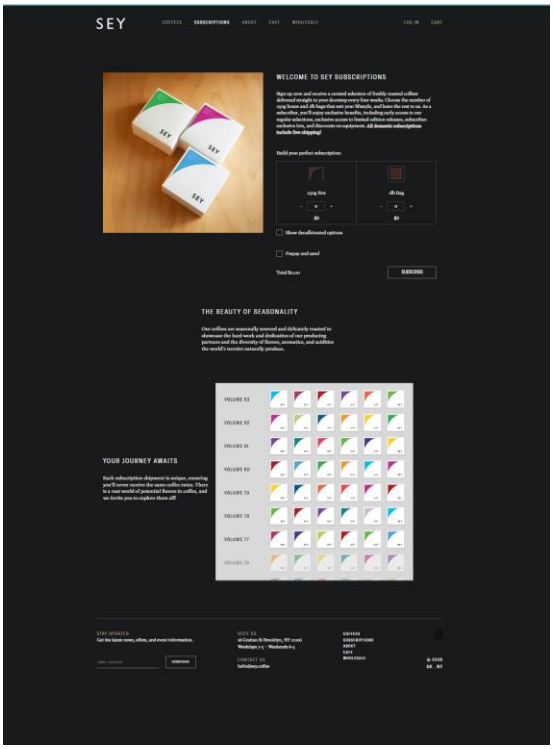


The site also supports **Recognition Rather Than Recall (Heuristic #6)** through consistent product imagery and structured grid layouts. Each coffee is represented by distinctive packaging colors and a standardized information format, allowing users to compare options quickly without remembering details from previous pages. The archive page further reinforces this principle by presenting past selections in the same visual style, making it easy to recognize familiar products.

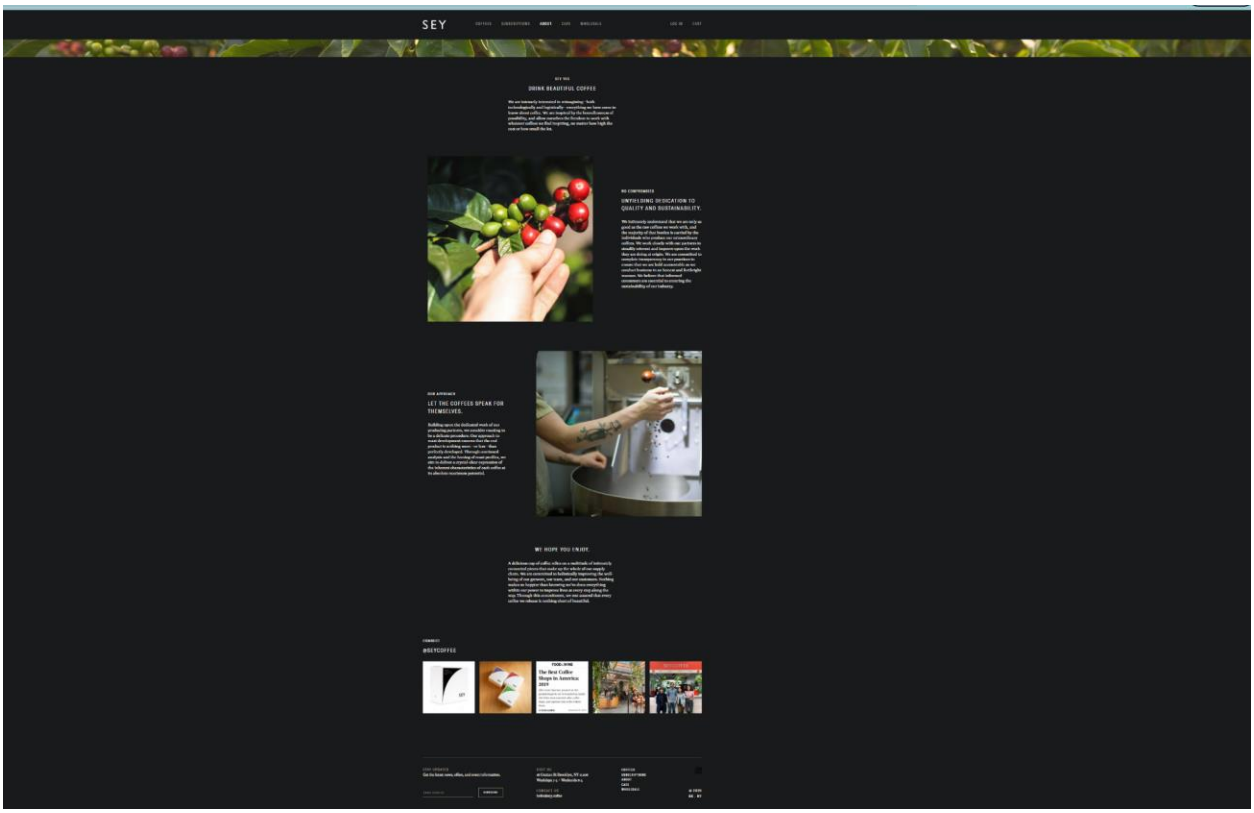
The subscription page demonstrates strong **User Control and Freedom (Heuristic #3)**. Users can customize quantities, view pricing updates, and select additional options without navigating away from the page. The process is straightforward and reversible, reducing the risk of accidental purchases and increasing confidence during decision-making.

Additionally, the site reflects **Consistency and Standards (Heuristic #4)**. Navigation categories such as Coffees, Subscriptions, About, and Wholesale align with typical e-commerce

conventions, making the interface easy to understand even for first-time visitors. Visual styling remains consistent across pages, reinforcing the brand identity while maintaining usability.



The large photographic header showing a coffee plantation supports **Match Between the System and the Real World (Heuristic #2)** by connecting the digital experience to the product's real-world origins. As users scroll, the image recedes and does not interfere with reading or interaction, maintaining a balance between storytelling and functionality.



However, the site presents issues related to **Accessibility and Readability (Heuristic #5: Error Prevention and Heuristic #7: Flexibility and Efficiency of Use)** due to the small font size used throughout the interface. While the typography contributes to the minimalist aesthetic, it reduces legibility, particularly for users with visual impairments or on smaller screens. Users may need to zoom in to read comfortably, which interrupts the browsing flow and may cause layout issues.

Overall, the SEY Coffee website achieves a strong balance between aesthetics and usability. The design is visually engaging, coherent, and easy to navigate, with structured layouts that support scanning and comparison. Improvements to text size and responsiveness would enhance accessibility while preserving the site's distinctive visual identity.